

RS Program: i-Group Survival Guide & Tips

A tips sheet for Yuteh Elementary teachers

1. Vocab is King: Extend Front Loading and Use Heavy Visuals

To effectively support your i-Group students, prioritize **extensive vocabulary front-loading**. This means introducing new words and concepts *before* the main lesson.

Key Strategies:

- **Heavy Visuals:** Utilize flashcards, pictures, realia, and diagrams to make vocabulary concrete and memorable. The more visual input, the better!
- **Discrete At-Home Chinese Notes:** For survival and to bridge understanding, simple, discrete Chinese translations or explanations in the margins of student materials can be a valuable tool. Ensure these are supplemental and do not replace English instruction.

2. Pre-Made Sentence Frames: Prevent the 'Freeze'

Combat student anxiety and the fear of not knowing what to say by providing **pre-made sentence frames**. These sentence starters offer a scaffold for communication and reduce cognitive load.

Tools to Use:

- **Gynzy:** Create interactive boards with sentence starters.
- **Classroomscreen:** Utilize its features to project visual sentence frames.
- **Canva:** Design visually appealing and easily accessible sentence frames for projection.

3. The Remedial Pipeline: Meticulous Documentation is Crucial

When working with i-Group students, **stick to the main text** as your primary resource. However, the most critical element for future support is meticulous documentation of student gaps.

Documentation Best Practices:

- **Identify Specific Gaps:** Note down precise areas where students struggle (e.g., specific grammar points, comprehension of certain vocabulary, pronunciation issues).
- **Data for Remedial Team:** This detailed documentation is *essential* for the remedial team to understand individual student needs later in the semester and to tailor interventions effectively.

4. Tangible Projects & Echo Reading for Safety

Make learning engaging and provide opportunities for students to demonstrate understanding through **tangible projects** and build confidence with **echo reading**.

Ideas for Application:

- **Mini-Posters:** Transform completed graphic organizers into small posters that students can present or display.
- **Paired Presentations:** Have students work in pairs to present information from their organizers or projects.
- **Whole-Class Echo Reading:** For a sense of safety and reduced individual pressure, engage in whole-class echo reading. You read a sentence or phrase, and students repeat it. This builds fluency and confidence in a supportive environment.

5. The AI Secret Weapon: Lowering Anxiety with Creative Outputs

Leverage the power of AI tools to create engaging pre-reading activities that **lower student anxiety** and prepare them for new material.

Utilizing School Resources:

- **School Canva Accounts:** Use your school's Canva subscription to design visual aids.
- **Gemini Accounts:** Utilize free school Gemini accounts for content generation.

Creative AI Applications:

- **Comic Strips:** Generate simple comic strips based on key vocabulary or plot points from upcoming reading material. This visual storytelling can make content more approachable.
- **Picture-Frame Summaries:** Create visual summaries of key concepts or characters. These serve as excellent pre-reading 'cheat sheets' that reduce the intimidation factor of new texts.

Summary of Key Takeaways

This guide provides practical strategies for supporting i-Group students. By focusing on **enhanced vocabulary acquisition** with visuals, providing **scaffolded sentence frames**, **meticulously documenting student progress**, engaging in **tangible project work** and **echo reading**, and strategically using **AI tools** for pre-reading anxiety reduction, you can create a more supportive and effective learning environment for all your students.